

Abdullah al-Khonaini

Contact Information

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Scholar of public administration and governance, completing a PhD in Middle Eastern and Islamic Studies at Durham University, UK (expected November 2026). Research expertise spans legislative institutions, political economy, and youth citizenship, with a focus on parliamentary committees, procedural design, and law and policy analysis. Works with qualitative and quantitative methods: primary archival research, elite interviews, process tracing, relational datasets, and Participatory Action Research (PAR). Graduate teaching experience and guest lecturer at Durham University. Founder of *Raqib50*, an online parliamentary database of the Kuwait National Assembly, awarded the Franco-German Prize for Human Rights and the Rule of Law (2017) and the Kuwait Award for Excellence and Creativity in Digital Media (2021) both for the work of *Raqib50*. Native Arabic speaker, fluent in English, and basic in Farsi.

Education

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| <p>❖ PhD, School of Government and International Affairs (SGIA), Durham University</p> <p>Thesis: ‘Rituals of Power: A Genealogy of the Parliamentary Committees of the Kuwaiti National Assembly, 1963–2024’</p> <p>Supervisors: Prof. Anoush Ehteshami and Prof. Bahar Baser. Institute for Middle Eastern and Islamic Studies (IMEIS).</p> | <p>Expected
Nov 2026</p> |
| <p>❖ MA in Power, Participation and Social Change, Institute of Development Studies (IDS), University of Sussex — <i>Distinction</i></p> <p>Thesis: ‘Critical Enquiry into the Marginalised Narratives of Expression: Reconstruction of Identity, Nationality, and Means of Participation in Kuwait’</p> | <p>2019</p> |
| <p>❖ BSc in Finance and Financial Institutions, College of Business Administration Kuwait University</p> | <p>2009</p> |

Research Interests

Public administration and governance; legislative institutions, committees and oversight; public budgeting and financial scrutiny; policy evaluation; political economy and social change; citizenship, migration and belonging; participatory action research; Arabian Peninsula, West Asia and North Africa.

Teaching Experience

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| <p>Graduate Teaching Assistant, SGIA, Durham University</p> <p><i>Perspectives of Political Economy (SGIA1241), undergraduate. Seminar leader; design of seminar materials, questions, and worksheets; office hours; formative marking and feedback.</i></p> <p>Student evaluation, Durham University Module Evaluation Questionnaire, April 2026: median 5.00, standard deviation 0.56 for quality of small-group teaching — at the departmental median (SGIA 5.00), above the module’s overall teaching median (4.00), and the lowest variance recorded for any teacher on the module. 24 of 25 respondents agreed or definitely agreed; none disagreed.</p> | <p>2025/26</p> |
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Mid-module student survey, 38 responses, February–March 2026: 29 students reported feeling encouraged to participate even when uncertain; 26 identified guided group discussion and 11 the textual-analysis exercise as most beneficial to their learning; 12 used office hours or written guidance and found it helpful.

Led six seminar groups (three per week, meeting fortnightly) for over 90 undergraduate students.

Courses prepared to teach: Policy Analysis and Design; Comparative Public Policy; Global Political Economy; Research Methods for Public Policy; Analytical Methods for Policy Evaluation; Digital Governance; International Relations of the Gulf; Perspectives in Gulf Studies; and supervision of Capstone Projects.

Peer-Reviewed Publications

Journal Articles

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| ‘Transposing Citizenship: Acts of Belonging and Locality Among the Non-Citizen Population in the Arabian Peninsula’, <i>Studies in Ethnicity and Nationalism</i> , 2026. | 2026 |
| ‘Governance as Obstacle: The Reproduction of Urban Path Dependencies in Kuwait’, <i>Urban Studies</i> , accepted for publication, co-authored in consortium. | 2026 |
| ‘Built to Separate: Quantifying Migrant Residential Segregation Throughout Kuwait’s Urban Transformation, 1957–2021’, co-authored in consortium (in preparation for submission). | Forthcoming |

Research and Policy Papers

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| ‘Spatial Patterns and Urban Governance in Kuwait: Exploring the Links Between the Physical, the Socio-Economic and the Political’, <i>London School of Economics (LSE) Middle East Centre Kuwait Programme Paper Series</i> , 25 (2024), co-authored in consortium. | 2024 |
| ‘Bringing Out the Participatory Action Research (PAR) in Participants: Reflections and Lessons from the Aswatna Programme: Educating for Inclusion’, white paper (Kuwait City: En.v, 2024), with Zainab Mirza. | 2024 |
| ‘Youth Citizenship Identities in Kuwait: The Role of Citizenship Education and the Kuwaiti Diwaniya’, <i>LSE Middle East Centre Kuwait Programme Paper Series</i> , 19 (2023), co-authored in consortium. | 2023 |

Book Chapters, Policy, and Public Writing

Book Chapters

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| ‘Citizenship Revocation and Opposition Fragmentation in Kuwait after the Arab Spring’, in <i>Breaking the Molds: Civil Society and Public Policymaking in the Arab World</i> , ed. by Fatima Moussawi and others (Beirut: Issam Fares Institute for Public Policy and International Affairs, American University of Beirut, and Dar Alfarabi, 2025) [in Arabic; English version available online]. | 2025 |
| ‘Re-examining Gender Norms in Kuwait: A Case Study of Article 198 of the Penal Code’, in <i>Breaking the Molds</i> (2025) [in Arabic; English version available online]. | 2025 |
| ‘Informal Advocacy: The Politics of Kuwait’s New Mental Health Law’, in <i>Breaking the Molds</i> (2025) [in Arabic; English version available online]. | 2025 |

- ‘The City and Socio-Sustainability in the Gulf States: The Northern Project’, in *The Enduring and the Evolving 2020: Sustainability in the Gulf*, ed. by Omar al-Shehabi and Hamad al-Rayes (Beirut: Gulf Centre for Development Policies and Centre for Arab Unity Studies, 2020) [in Arabic]. 2020
- ‘The Political Development in Kuwait: Summarising the Events of the Year 2019’, in *The Enduring and the Evolving 2020* [in Arabic]. 2020

Policy Writings

- ‘How Should the Biden Administration Support Human Rights and Democracy in the MENA? (Kuwait’s Case)’, Project on Middle East Democracy, Washington, D.C., 2021. 2021
- ‘How COVID-19 Stress-Tested the Relations between Residents and Citizens’, Gulf International Forum, Washington, D.C., 2020. 2020
- ‘Kuwait Debate Power over Citizenship’, Arab Gulf States Institute in Washington (AGSIW), 2017. 2017

Public Writings

- ‘Kuwait Voted This Weekend. Who Won?’, *Washington Post*, Good Authority (formerly The Monkey Cage), 2020, with Daniel Tavana. 2020
- ‘Examining the KNA: How Did the Mayoral Legislation Originate?’, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021 [in Arabic]. 2021
- ‘Understanding Kuwait’s Bureaucracy’, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021 [in Arabic]. 2021
- ‘Explainer: How Do We Understand the Kuwaiti State Budget?’, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021, with Salman al-Naqi [in Arabic]. 2021
- ‘In Its Sixteenth Anniversary: Why Do Protesters Choose al-Erada Square?’, *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021 [in Arabic]. 2021

Research Funding, Fellowship, and Commissioned Research

- General Sir Peter de la Billière Doctoral Fellow, Al-Sabah Programme Doctoral Training Programme, SGIA, Durham University 2022–2025
- Lead Researcher (commissioned), ‘Gender Political Economy Analysis in Kuwait’ Westminster Foundation for Democracy, London 2021–2022
- Lead Researcher (commissioned), Evaluation and Monitoring Report of the Legal Unit Aid Programme, Kuwait Trade Union Federation, International Labour Organization (ILO) 2022
- Researcher (commissioned), ‘Restructuring the Kuwaiti Government’, Kuwait Foundation for the Advancement of Sciences (KFAS) with the Supreme Council for Planning and Development 2021
- Leaders for Democracy Fellowship, U.S.–Middle East Partnership Initiative, Center for Politics, University of Virginia 2017

Awards

Kuwait Award for Excellence and Creativity in Digital Media, Ministry of Youth Affairs, for the work of <i>Raqib50</i>	2021
Franco-German Prize for Human Rights and the Rule of Law, Franco-German Council of Ministers, for the work of <i>Raqib50</i>	2017

Research and Professional Positions

Editor, <i>Manshoor</i> , Kuwait City	2020–2021
Research Assistant, ‘Neighbourhood Tales: Kuwait Under Lockdown’ oral history project, En.v, Kuwait City	2020
Research Assistant, KFAS Needs Assessment Project, KFAS and En.v	2019
Research Assistant, ‘The National Youth Policy in Kuwait’, Ministry of Youth Affairs with Louis Berger	2018
Research Assistant, Rai Institute for Research and Strategic Studies, Kuwait City	2014–2018
Research Intern, AGSIW, Washington, D.C. — three-month placement under the Leaders for Democracy Fellowship, supervised by Dr Kristin Diwan; wrote published commentary and internal reports; supported the organisation of conferences and seminars.	2017
Contractor/Accountant, Foreign Procurement Department, Ministry of Defence, Kuwait City	2011–2014

Research Training Design and PAR

Designer and Convener, Training of Trainers, ‘Strengthening Migrant Rights’ PAR workshop (two days), En.v with the ILO and Kuwait Manpower Public Authority, Kuwait City	2024
Designer and Convener, Training of Trainers, ‘Enbat: Nurturing Transformational Leadership’ PAR workshop (five days), Kuwait Projects Company (KIPCO), Kuwait City	2022
Designer and Convener, Training of Trainers, ‘Aswatna: Educating for Inclusion’ PAR programme (six days), En.v and Data4Change, Kuwait City	2021
Facilitator, ‘Build: Collaborative Ideathon for Community in Crisis’ PAR workshops (eight days, online), En.v with the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation and Gray Area Collective	2020
Facilitator, ‘N-mu: Youth Engagement Programme’ PAR workshops (five days), En.v with the Eurasia Foundation and the International Research and Exchanges Board, Kuwait City	2016

Conference Participation

British Society for Middle Eastern Studies (BRISMES) Annual Conference — Attendee, and hosted the Association for Gulf and Arabian Peninsula Studies (AGAPS) coffee meetup	2026
Paper, ‘From Housing to Cybersecurity: A Genealogy of Society-State Relations in the Kuwait National Assembly’, IMEIS Annual Conference, Durham University	2026
Paper, ‘Behind the Budgetary Process: The Politics of Parliamentary Committees, Procedures and the Formulation of the State Budget in Kuwait’, IMEIS Annual Conference, Durham University	2025

Workshop, ‘The Politics of Identity in the Middle East and North Africa’, American Political Science Association (APSA) MENA Workshop, Kuwait University	2024
Roundtable, ‘Revisiting Gulf Studies: An Interdisciplinary Approach to Scope, Theory, and Data’, British International Studies Association (BISA) Annual Conference, Birmingham	2024
Paper, ‘Kuwaiti Youth and the Evolution of the “Democratic Diwaniya”’, Middle East Studies Association (MESA) Annual Meeting	2021
Panel Chair and Discussant, ‘Excavating Modernity in the Arab Gulf: The Case of Kuwait’, MESA Annual Meeting	2020
Panel Paper, ‘Politics Beyond the Political: The Case of Kuwait’, MESA Annual Meeting	2020
Paper, ‘Civil Society and Policymaking in the Arab World’, Issam Fares Institute — Breaking the Mold, Beirut	2019
Panel, ‘Unpacking the Role of Civil Society Organizations’, Nuqat Creative Conference, Kuwait City	2018
Panel, ‘Assessing Civic Space in the Middle East and North Africa: The Case of Kuwait’, International Center for Not-for-Profit Law, Beirut	2017

Invited Lectures, Webinar, and Workshops

Guest Lecturer, ‘Comparative Politics of the Gulf’ module, by Dr Mustafa Elmenshawi, Lancaster University	2024
Webinar, ‘Youth Politics in MENA and Beyond: Activism, Political Participation, and Inclusive Peacebuilding’, BISA	2024
Workshop, ‘Youth and Youth Policy in the Global Political Economy’ module, by Prof Emma Murhpy, Durham University	2023
Webinar, ‘Kuwait Goes to the Polls: Discussing the 2020 Parliamentary Elections’, LSE Middle East Centre, London	2020
Webinar, ‘Kuwait’s Election: Political and Economic Challenges’, Gulf International Forum, Washington, D.C.	2020
Lecture, ‘Accountability and Transparency in the National Assembly’, Women’s Cultural and Social Society, Kuwait City	2019
Lectures, ‘Who is Censoring Us?’ (Hikma Society); ‘Examining Grassroots Civil Groups in Kuwait’ (George Washington University); ‘Challenges to Civil Society in Kuwait’ and ‘NGOs and Non-Profits as a Driver for Sustainable Development’ (Kuwait University)	2017

Service and Professional Affiliations

Graduate Student Representative (non-voting) Board Member, AGAPS	2025–2026
Organiser, IMEIS Café monthly peer-to-peer research sessions, IMEIS, Durham University	2025–2026
Elected MA Representative, Staff–Student Committee, IDS, University of Sussex	2018–2019

Civic Engagement and Public Impact

Founder, <i>Raqib50</i> — parliamentary database and application publishing the record of the Kuwait National Assembly accessible to the public	2013–present
Research and Policy Advisor, <i>En.v</i> , non-voting advisory member	2020–present

Lead Strategist, Constitutional Court Case — Abolition of penalties related to article 198 of the Penal Code, verdict: article abolished	2020–2022
Policy Advocate, campaign to amend censorship provisions of the Press and Publication Law, Kuwait National Assembly	2016–2020

Languages and Skills

Languages: Arabic (native), English (fluent), Farsi (basic).

Software: NVivo, Qualtrics, R, Obsidian, Microsoft Office.

References

References are upon request